

2000-2009

The DECADE that changed the world Telecom Transformation

spirit of india special

Kings of THE RING

PRAMOD MAHAJAN As telecom minister, he deregulated the sector, opening up the market to new players like Reliance.



DAYANIDHI MARAN The former minister not only effected a reduction in call rates, but also got \$20 billion of investment for the sector.



A. RAJA The Union telecom minister is credited with having brought in competitive tariffs and auctioning the 2G spectrum, amid allegations of corruption.



SUNIL BHARTI MITTAL The head of Bharti Airtel brought mobile telephony to our doorstep and the concept of free lifetime incoming calls in prepaid services.



ANIL AMBANI His Reliance Communications was the first to operate in both CDMA as well as GSM technologies. In 2003, it made handsets along with connections available for only Rs 500.



TATA DOCOMO The Tata Teleservices-NTT DoCoMo alliance has taken the industry by storm with its 1 paisa per second plan, and 1 paisa per SMS character.



SPECTRUM, BEING SCARCE, should not be allocated free to any operator

RATAN TATA,
CHAIRMAN, TATA GROUP

In many cities, customers can use their mobiles to request radio taxis at any time and place and receive confirmation by text messages within minutes. Mobile phones also help car and taxi drivers better manage their time while providing good service to their clients. When clients need to go from one place to another for meetings, they do not have to run around in search of the spot at which their car or taxi driver waits on them. Instead, a "missed call" to the driver quickly brings the car to them.

With relatively low Internet penetration in India—there are only 14.05 million Internet subscribers—mobile banking is fast spreading. Already, there now exist 20 to 25 million registered users of mobile banking. This opens the possibility of

short-term borrowing and lending among friends and relatives located in far off places. Mobile phones have also become useful for the practice of tele-medicine. Pictures or short video clips of a patient, shot and transmitted using mobile phones, can allow a doctor in a distant location to offer preliminary diagnosis. Dr Ashok Panagariya, head of the department of neurology at the SMS Medical College, Jaipur, tells me that video recordings of seizure episodes by family members using mobile phones can provide information useful for distinguishing attacks affecting the brain from non-epileptic attacks.

With processing power, storage capacity and bandwidth rapidly expanding, the uses of mobile phones is going to continue multiplying in areas such as finance, commerce, medicine, entertainment, event management and agriculture. It is altogether possible that in the future, phones will entirely replace conventional computers.

Arvind Panagariya is a professor at Columbia University and author of India: The Emerging Giant

